



SIX MINUTE WALK TEST GUIDELINE

Insurance companies want updated objective data showing that the patient needs portable oxygen therapy. To do this, the provider can use one of two qualification pathways:

Pathway 1: Room Air at Rest

- What to do: Measure the patient's oxygen saturation while they are resting and breathing room air (i.e., without any supplemental oxygen).
- Qualification Criterion: If the saturation level is 88% or below, this meets the requirement for portable oxygen.

Pathway 2: Exercise Testing

This pathway is a bit more involved and consists of three distinct steps, sometimes referred to as the "three step exercise test." The steps are:

1. Step A – Resting Saturation without Oxygen:

- Action: Measure the patient's oxygen saturation while at rest and breathing room air.
- Purpose: This establishes a baseline measurement before any activity begins.

2. Step B – Exertional Saturation without Oxygen:

- Action: Have the patient perform an activity, such as walking or another form of exertion, still while breathing room air.
- **Qualification Criterion:**
 - The key measurement here is that their oxygen saturation drops to 88% or below during exertion.
 - This indicates that the patient experiences significant desaturation when active, which can justify the need for supplemental oxygen.

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3. Step C – Exertional Saturation with Oxygen:

Action: Have the patient perform the same type of exertional activity, but now with the prescribed flow of supplemental oxygen administered.

- **Purpose:** This helps to document the therapeutic effect of oxygen during activity.
- It shows that oxygen therapy makes a meaningful difference, which can support the ongoing need for portable oxygen.

Alternative Testing: Arterial Blood Gas (ABG) Measurement

What to do:

Perform an arterial blood gas test while the patient is breathing room air.

Qualification Criterion:

- Check the PO₂ (partial pressure of oxygen) level.
- If the PO₂ is 55 mmHg or below, this also qualifies the patient for portable oxygen therapy.

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AdaptHealth • 122 Mill Rd, Suite 120 • Oaks, PA 19460

P: 484-567-0666 • F: 484-362-1480 • Adapthealth.com